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5 Custom Software Projects That Pay for Themselves in 12 Months

A practical guide for UK SMEs looking to invest in bespoke software

Custom software that pays for itself.

Introduction

Off-the-shelf software rarely fits your business perfectly. You adapt your process to the tool, pay ongoing licences, and still end up with spreadsheets bridging the gaps. This guide covers five custom software projects that UK SMEs are building right now, each with a clear payback timeline.

For each project we cover what it is, how it works, typical results, and what it costs to build. The figures are based on real client work with businesses of 10 to 250 employees.

The point is not that bespoke software is always better. It is that for the right process, a custom build can pay for itself within 12 to 18 months and then keep saving you money every year after that, with no per-seat licence fees.

#	Opportunity	Cost	Payback
1	Custom CRM That Fits Your Sales Process	25,000 to 40,000	12 to 18 months
2	Automated Invoice Processing System	8,000 to 15,000	6 to 12 months
3	Integrated Job Management Platform	25,000 to 50,000	12 to 18 months
4	Bespoke Client Portal	15,000 to 30,000	12 to 18 months
5	System Integration Layer (CRM + Accounting + ERP)	8,000 to 20,000	6 to 12 months

1

Custom CRM That Fits Your Sales Process

What it is

A customer relationship management system built around your actual sales workflow, not a generic template. It captures every lead, tracks deals through your custom stages, and gives you real-time pipeline visibility without forcing your team to adapt to someone else's process.

How it works

We map your existing sales process, then build a CRM that mirrors it exactly. Leads enter from your website, referrals, or manual entry. Each deal moves through stages you define. Dashboards show your pipeline at a glance. Integrations with your email, calendar, and accounting tools mean data flows automatically, with no double entry.

Typical results

- 40 to 60 per cent reduction in administrative time
- No lost leads: every enquiry is tracked from first contact to close
- Real-time pipeline visibility for the whole team
- Custom reporting that answers your actual business questions

BUILD COST**£25,000 to 40,000****PAYBACK****12 to 18 months**

Why bespoke vs off-the-shelf

HubSpot Professional costs around 15,000 per year and Salesforce Enterprise around 60,000 per year, and neither fits your process out of the box.

2

Automated Invoice Processing System

What it is

Software that reads, validates, and routes incoming invoices automatically. Supplier invoices arrive by email or upload, get extracted and checked against purchase orders, then flow through approval workflows before reaching your accounting system.

How it works

Invoices arrive by email or portal upload. Optical character recognition reads the key fields: supplier, amount, date, line items. The system matches each invoice against purchase orders or delivery notes. Discrepancies are flagged for review. Approved invoices post straight to your accounting software.

Typical results

- 70 per cent reduction in processing time
- Fewer errors from manual data entry
- Faster approvals with automatic routing
- Full audit trail for every invoice

BUILD COST**£8,000 to 15,000****PAYBACK****6 to 12 months**

Why bespoke vs off-the-shelf

Most teams processing 200 or more invoices per month recover the build cost within the first year on staff time alone.

3

Integrated Job Management Platform

What it is

A single platform that manages jobs, schedules, time tracking, and job costing. Replace the spread of spreadsheets, whiteboards, and separate tools with one system that everyone uses, from the office to the field.

How it works

Jobs are created and assigned with deadlines and resources. The system tracks time against each job, manages materials, and produces job cost reports. Scheduling views show who is doing what and when. Mobile access means field staff update status and log time from anywhere.

Typical results

- 3 to 5 hours saved per person per week
- Accurate job costing with real-time data
- Better resource allocation and scheduling
- One source of truth across the business

BUILD COST**£25,000 to 50,000****PAYBACK****12 to 18 months**

Why bespoke vs off-the-shelf

Generic tools like Monday.com or Jobber force you into their structure. A bespoke platform fits yours exactly and integrates with your accounting and payroll.

4

Bespoke Client Portal

What it is

A secure, branded online portal where your clients can access documents, track project progress, raise queries, and approve work. It replaces the email chains and scattered file shares that create communication overhead and lost information.

How it works

Each client gets a secure login. They see their projects, documents, timelines, and status updates. They can raise queries through the portal instead of email. Approvals happen in one place with a full audit trail. You control what each client sees.

Typical results

- 50 to 70 per cent reduction in client communication overhead
- Fewer lost emails and duplicated information
- Professional, branded experience for every client
- Full audit trail of all client interactions

BUILD COST**£15,000 to 30,000****PAYBACK****12 to 18 months**

Why bespoke vs off-the-shelf

This pays for itself through the time saved chasing emails, re-sending documents, and managing status updates across multiple clients.

5

System Integration Layer (CRM + Accounting + ERP)

What it is

A middleware layer that connects your existing systems so data flows automatically between them. No more exporting CSVs from one tool to import into another. No more keeping three copies of the same customer record in sync manually.

How it works

We build an integration layer that sits between your CRM, accounting, ERP, and any other systems. Data changes in one system flow to the others automatically. We handle the mapping, error handling, and logging so you can trust the data is correct.

Typical results

- 50 per cent reduction in data admin time
- Consistent data across all systems
- Eliminates manual export and import routines
- Full error logging and retry handling

BUILD COST**£8,000 to 20,000****PAYBACK****6 to 12 months**

Why bespoke vs off-the-shelf

If your team spends more than 5 hours per week moving data between systems, this pays for itself in months, not years.

Book a free, no-obligation 30-minute discovery call. We will talk through your business, your goals, and whether bespoke software makes sense for you right now.

Book a free call: <https://ajairu.dev/contact>

Email: hello@ajairu.dev



ajairu

Custom software for UK SMEs.

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